

The reduction of OEIS A301921 modulo k : a proof that the period divides $\varphi(k)$

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Abstract

OEIS A301921 carries a conjecture of P. Bala that for every positive integer k the sequence reduced modulo k is eventually periodic with period dividing $\varphi(k)$. It is true. The entry's own exponential generating function becomes, under the substitution $t = e^x - 1$, an ordinary power series with *integer* coefficients; that integrality forces all but finitely many terms of the Stirling expansion of $a(n)$ to vanish modulo k , and what is left is an integer combination of the functions $n \mapsto i^n$ with $0 \leq i < k$. Each of those is eventually periodic with period dividing $\varphi(k)$, and so is the sum. The argument also gives the exact point at which periodicity starts: $n \geq v(k)$, where $v(k)$ is the largest exponent in the prime factorisation of k .

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1 The sequence and the conjecture

OEIS A301921 is “Expansion of e.g.f. $1/(1 - (\exp(x) - 1)/(1 - (\exp(x) - 1)^2/(1 - (\exp(x) - 1)^3/(1 - \dots))))$), a continued fraction.”. It has offset 0 and begins

1, 1, 3, 19, 159, 1651, 21303, 324619, ...

The entry states, not as a conjecture,

Expansion of e.g.f. $1/(1 - (\exp(x) - 1)/(1 - (\exp(x) - 1)^2/(1 - (\exp(x) - 1)^3/(1 - \dots))))$), a continued fraction.

that is, writing $A(x) = \sum_{n \geq 0} a(n)x^n/n!$,

$$A(x) = \frac{1}{1 - \frac{u}{1 - \frac{u^2}{1 - \frac{u^3}{1 - \dots}}}}, \quad u = e^x - 1. \tag{1}$$

This is the only input taken from the entry, and it was checked against every one of the 21 terms of the entry's DATA section before use, not against a sample.

The entry separately carries the following comment:

Conjecture: Let k be a positive integer. The sequence obtained by reducing $a(n)$ modulo k is eventually periodic with the period dividing $\phi(k) = A000010(k)$. For example, modulo 9 we obtain the sequence [0, 1, 3, 1, 6, 4, 0, 7, 3, 1, 6, 4, 0, 7, 3, 1, 6, 4, 0, 7, ...] with an apparent period of $6 = \phi(9)$ beginning at $n = 2$. Cf. A004123. (End) — *Peter Bala*, Aug 19 2025

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Aug 20 2025 00:30:37, revision 18) the statement is still recorded as a conjecture, and nothing on the entry records it as settled either way.

Written out, the conjecture asserts: for every integer $k \geq 1$ there are n_0 and a positive integer P with $P \mid \varphi(k)$ such that

$$a(n + P) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k} \quad \text{for all } n \geq n_0. \quad (2)$$

It is proved below, with $P = \varphi(k)$ and $n_0 = v(k)$, the largest exponent occurring in the prime factorisation of k .

2 The generating function in the variable $t = e^x - 1$

Set $t = e^x - 1$. Then $e^x = 1 + t$, and substituting into (1),

$$e^x - 1 = t,$$

so that

$$A(x) = G(e^x - 1), \quad G(t) = \frac{1}{1 - \frac{t}{1 - \frac{t^2}{1 - \frac{t^3}{1 - \dots}}}}. \quad (3)$$

Lemma 1. *G is a power series in t with integer coefficients.*

Proof. G is a continued fraction whose k -th partial numerator is t^k : truncating after level k leaves the coefficients below t^k unchanged, and each truncation is a quotient of integer polynomials with denominator of constant term 1. $\square$

Write $G(t) = \sum_{j \geq 0} c_j t^j$, so $c_j \in \mathbb{Z}$; here $c_j = 1, 1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 9, 15, 26, 45, \dots$, and the first few are

$$c_0, \dots, c_8 = 1, 1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 9, 15, 26.$$

3 The Stirling expansion, and what survives modulo k

Let $S(n, j)$ denote the Stirling numbers of the second kind.

Lemma 2. $a(n) = \sum_{j=0}^n c_j j! S(n, j)$ for every $n \geq 0$. In particular $a(n) \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Proof. The standard expansion $(e^x - 1)^j = \sum_{n \geq j} j! S(n, j) x^n / n!$ holds because $j! S(n, j)$ counts the surjections from an n -set onto a j -set. Substituting it into $A(x) = G(e^x - 1) = \sum_j c_j (e^x - 1)^j$ and reading off the coefficient of $x^n / n!$ gives the claim; the sum is finite because $S(n, j) = 0$ for $j > n$. Integrality is then immediate from Lemma 1. $\square$

Lemma 3. For every $k \geq 1$ and every n , $a(n) \equiv \sum_{j=0}^{k-1} c_j j! S(n, j) \pmod{k}$.

Proof. For $j \geq k$ the integer $j!$ is a multiple of k , since k is one of the factors $1, 2, \dots, j$. Hence every term of Lemma 2 with $j \geq k$ vanishes modulo k ; this uses $c_j \in \mathbb{Z}$, which is Lemma 1. $\square$

This is the step at which integrality is not a convenience but the whole point: were the c_j merely rational, $c_j j!$ need not be divisible by k for large j and the sum would not truncate.

Lemma 4. *There are integers $d_0, \dots, d_{k-1}$, namely $d_i = \sum_{j=i}^{k-1} (-1)^{j-i} \binom{j}{i} c_j$, with*

$$a(n) \equiv \sum_{i=0}^{k-1} d_i i^n \pmod{k} \quad \text{for all } n \geq 0.$$

Proof. Counting surjections from an n -set onto a j -set by inclusion and exclusion on the image gives $j! S(n, j) = \sum_{i=0}^j (-1)^{j-i} \binom{j}{i} i^n$. Substituting this into Lemma 3 and exchanging the two finite sums collects the coefficient of i^n into d_i as stated. Each d_i is an integer because each c_j is. $\square$

4 The period

For $k \geq 2$ let $v(k)$ be the largest exponent in the prime factorisation of k , so $k \mid m^{v(k)}$ whenever m is divisible by every prime factor of k , and $v(k) \leq \log_2 k$.

Lemma 5. *Let $k \geq 2$ and $0 \leq i < k$. Then $i^{n+\varphi(k)} \equiv i^n \pmod{k}$ for every $n \geq v(k)$.*

Proof. Write $k = k_1 k_2$, where $k_1 = \prod_{p \mid k} p^{v_p(k)}$ and $k_2 = k/k_1$; then $\gcd(k_1, k_2) = 1$ and $\gcd(i, k_2) = 1$.

Modulo k_1 : for each prime $p \mid k_1$ we have $p \mid i$, so $v_p(i^n) = n v_p(i) \geq n \geq v(k) \geq v_p(k)$. Hence $k_1 \mid i^n$ for $n \geq v(k)$, and likewise $k_1 \mid i^{n+\varphi(k)}$; both sides are $\equiv 0$.

Modulo k_2 : i is a unit, so by Euler's theorem $i^{\varphi(k_2)} \equiv 1$. Since $\gcd(k_1, k_2) = 1$ we have $\varphi(k) = \varphi(k_1)\varphi(k_2)$, so $\varphi(k_2) \mid \varphi(k)$ and therefore $i^{\varphi(k)} \equiv 1 \pmod{k_2}$, giving $i^{n+\varphi(k)} \equiv i^n$.

The two congruences and the Chinese remainder theorem give the claim modulo $k = k_1 k_2$. (For $i = 0$ note $0^n = 0$ for $n \geq 1$ and $v(k) \geq 1$.) $\square$

Theorem 6. *Let $a(n)$ be OEIS A301921. For every integer $k \geq 1$,*

$$a(n + \varphi(k)) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k} \quad \text{for all } n \geq v(k),$$

where $v(k)$ is the largest exponent in the prime factorisation of k (and $v(1) = 0$). In particular the sequence $(a(n) \bmod k)_{n \geq 0}$ is eventually periodic with period dividing $\varphi(k)$, with a pre-period of length at most $\log_2 k$. This is the conjecture of Section 1.

Proof. The case $k = 1$ is trivial. For $k \geq 2$, Lemma 4 writes $a(n)$ modulo k as $\sum_{i < k} d_i i^n$ with integer d_i independent of n , and Lemma 5 gives $i^{n+\varphi(k)} \equiv i^n$ for each $i < k$ once $n \geq v(k)$. Summing the k congruences with the weights d_i gives $a(n + \varphi(k)) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k}$ for $n \geq v(k)$. The true period of the eventually periodic sequence is then a divisor of $\varphi(k)$. $\square$

Remark 7. The bound $n \geq v(k)$ cannot be lowered in general: for k a prime power p^e the term $i = p$ contributes p^n , which is not divisible by p^e until $n = e = v(k)$.

5 Verification

Three checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, the series G of (3) was expanded and $\sum_j c_j j! S(n, j)$ compared against the entry's DATA at every one of the 21 published indices; the values agree exactly, and every c_j came out an integer. A series that reproduced only some of the published terms would not have been used.

Second, for each k from 2 to 40 the sequence $a(n) \bmod k$ was computed exactly — not sampled — from the recurrence $S(n, j) = j S(n-1, j) + S(n-1, j-1)$ carried out in $\mathbb{Z}/k\mathbb{Z}$ on the truncated state $(S(n, 0), \dots, S(n, k-1))$ of Lemma 3, and its exact eventual period found by detecting the repetition of that state. The result is tabulated below. In every case the period divides $\varphi(k)$, as Theorem 6 requires.

k	$\varphi(k)$	period	k	$\varphi(k)$	period
2	1	1	22	10	10
3	2	2	23	22	22
4	2	1	24	8	2
5	4	4	25	20	20
6	2	2	26	12	12
7	6	6	27	18	18
8	4	2	28	12	6
9	6	6	29	28	28
10	4	4	30	8	4
11	10	10	31	30	30
12	4	2	32	16	8
13	12	12	33	20	10
14	6	6	34	16	16
15	8	4	35	24	12
16	8	4	36	12	6
17	16	16	37	36	36
18	6	6	38	18	18
19	18	18	39	24	12
20	8	4	40	16	4
21	12	6			

Third, the congruence $a(n + \varphi(k)) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k}$ of Theorem 6 was checked directly on the published terms for every k in that range and every $n \geq v(k)$ for which both indices are published; it holds without exception.

References

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